

Session 25: Literary Design of Genesis 4

Key Takeaways

- Genesis 4 develops themes introduced in previous chapters: knowing, conception, birth, grief, the ground, and testing.
- Genesis 4 also introduces new themes: the voice of the blood of the innocent, the city of blood, farmers and shepherds, and sibling rivalry.

Macro Design of Genesis 4:1-26

Genesis 4 is broken into two large narrative panels, punctuated by three birth scenes.

Scenes		Overview
A: 4:1-2: Birth Scene 1		"and the human knew his wife Eve, and she conceived and she gave birth..." Two sons born: • Cain + wordplay on son's name • Abel (=“vapor”)
	B: 4:3-16: Narrative Panel 1	Cain murders his brother Abel • v. 3-7: The sacrifices and Cain's test • v. 8-11: Cain murders his brother and dialogue with Yahweh • v. 12-16: God's punishment and his mercy on Cain God's mercy: 7x blood vengeance declared for Cain
A: 4:17-18: Birth Scene 2		"And Cain knew his wife and she conceived and gave birth to Enoch..." • Builds a city named after his son
	B: 4:19-24: Narrative Panel 2	Lemek murders a young man • v. 19: Lemek's two wives • v. 20-22: Lemek's three sons • v. 23-24: Lemek's murderous poem Lemek declares 77x blood vengeance on himself
Cain and Abel: A Tale of Two Seeds. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).		

Scenes	Overview
A: 4:25-26: Birth Scene 3	“And the human knew again his wife and she gave birth to a son...” Two sons born: • Seth + wordplay on son’s name • Enosh (= “humanity”)
<i>Cain and Abel: A Tale of Two Seeds.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).	

“Throughout the Pentateuch, the sevenfold use of divine speech formula is commonplace, and within this chapter the number seven is clearly significant (cf. vv 15, 24). Unusually full details about Lamek, the seventh generation from Adam (vv 18-24), may illustrate another convention associated with biblical genealogies, a tendency to draw attention to the seventh generation. Indeed various keywords in the narrative appear a multiple of seven times. Within 4:1-17, ‘Abel’ and ‘brother’ occur seven times, and ‘Cain’ fourteen times. Within the whole of 2:4-4:26, אֶרֶץ ‘earth,’ not ‘land of,’ is mentioned seven times, אֲדָמָה ‘land’ fourteen times, and ‘God,’ ‘the Lord,’ or ‘The Lord God’ some thirty-four times, exactly matching the thirty-five occurrences of ‘God’ in 1:1-2:3. The last verse of chap. 4, ‘At that time people began to call on the name of the Lord,’ thus contains the seventieth mention of the deity in Genesis and the fourteenth use of the key word ‘call’... In all these respects chapter 4 is entirely typical of the editorial techniques used throughout Genesis, and its present form must owe much to the final editor.”

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [Genesis 1-15 \(Word Biblical Commentary\)](#). Thomas Nelson Inc.

Eve’s Many Sons: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 4:1-2 and 4:25-26

Birth Scene #1: Eve “Creates” a Son

- a ¹ Now, **the human knew his wife Eve**,
b **and she conceived and she gave birth** to **Cain (קַיִן)**
c and she said, "I have **created (קָנִיתִי)** a man (in comparison) with Yahweh."
b ^{2a} and again she gave birth to his brother **Abel**,

Birth Scene #3: God “Appoints” a Son

²⁵ **and Adam knew his wife again**
and she gave birth to a son,
and she named him "Seth (שֵׁת)," because,
“God has appointed (שָׂת) me another seed in place of Abel, for Cain killed him.”

²⁶ and to Seth, to him also a son was born;
and he called his name Enosh.
then it was begun, to call on the name of Yahweh.

The Cain and Abel Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

Observations About the Two Birth Scenes

The opening and closing birth scenes (4:1-2; 4:25-26) provide a matching frame of Eve's pregnancy, birth, and naming of sons. The similarities also highlight some important contrasts.

"I have created a man ..."

Eve's words in 4:1 could be taken as a celebration of divine assistance ("with Yahweh" = "with Yahweh's assistance"). More likely, they are a statement of her budding arrogance: "I have created a man, alongside/in comparison with Yahweh." The likelihood of this interpretation is supported by many observations of the following narrative.

Eve's words "I have created a man ..." contain the Hebrew root קנ"ה, which appears elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible to describe God as creator of the world (Gen. 14:19, 22), of Israel (Deut. 32:6), of people (Ps. 139:13), and of wisdom (Prov. 8:22). Since divine procreation is often connected with this verse, and it is never used of "acquiring" children, it's more likely that Eve is attributing the creation of Cain to her own power and ability (cf. the warning against attributing God's power to oneself in , and of wisdom Deut. 8:11-18).

"With Yahweh ..."

Many translations interpret the "with" (אִתּוֹ) as Yahweh's agency, meaning that Eve is attributing her pregnancy to Yahweh (Septuagint διὰ τοῦ Θεοῦ; "with the help of the LORD" NASB; ESV; NIV). But the word is more likely implying a comparison: "beside, in comparison with Yahweh." This is a common use of "with." Exodus 20:23 says, "Do not make any gods alongside/in comparison with me (אִתִּי)," and Genesis 39:6 says, "And Potiphar left everything in the hand of Joseph and didn't know anything alongside/in comparison with him (אִתּוֹ)."

With this interpretation, the narrative is portraying Eve (once again) as a human who uses their God-given abilities to create their own blessing by their own wisdom and power. Eve would then be the first of many mothers in Genesis to try to achieve or attribute the divine blessing of children to their own plan or power. Compare Sarai in Genesis 16:1-16, Rebekah in Genesis 27:1-46, and Leah and Rachel in Genesis 30:1-43. This would also explain why God accepts the younger son's offering, in order to subvert human wisdom and power, as he does in each of the generations.

"The first woman, in her joy at giving birth to her first son, boasts of her generative power, which approximates in her estimation to the Divine creative power. The Lord formed the first man (2:7), and I have formed the second man. Literally, 'I have created a man with the Lord' = I stand together [i.e. equally] with him in the rank of creators."

Cassuto, U. (1961). [A Commentary on the Book of Genesis \(Part I\): from Adam to Noah](#). Magnes Press.

The Contrast of Eve's Words in 4:1 and 4:25

Eve's words about her sons open and close the chapter (4:1 and 4:25), and they contrast each other. In Genesis 4:1 she says, "I have created a man alongside Yahweh," and in 4:25 she says, "God has given me a seed, another one in the place of Abel, for Cain murdered him." Her opening words of hubris are subverted while her closing words accept Seth as a generous gift after the tragic loss of Abel that ironically overturned her presumptive words. Additionally, 4:25 provides a kind of reversal of Abel's death.

"Although Seth is not Abel, he is said to stand 'in the place of' the dead son in a more profound sense ... Seth is Abel *redivivus* [= 'revived'], the slain son restored to his parents. His birth is proof that the loss of the son favored by God's inscrutable grace is not final. The death of the beloved son, even when it is not averted, can still be reversed."

Levenson, Jon D. (1995). "Favor and Fratricide." [*The Death and Resurrection of the Beloved Son: The Transformation of Child Sacrifice in Judaism and Christianity*](#). Yale University Press.

Reflection Question

Genesis 4 begins and ends with Eve giving birth to a son. Compare what Eve says in Genesis 4:1 to her words in Genesis 4:25. What do you notice? How would you describe the differences between the two statements?